

Here's to better interaction in 2013

It would be an understatement to say technology has changed the way we do simple things these days – but out of all that we do in the course of our lives, for this column, I want to focus on interaction. This aspect of our human side has over the years taken on a completely new meaning. We use status messages, social media tools, and our smartphones as a conduit to have our fair share of interaction with people – often times more so than physically meeting with them in real life. In effect, all the efforts to connect have left us that much more disconnected. And distracted. You won't believe the number of times I got distracted in the course of writing this piece – whether it was by the beep of a WhatsApp message on my phone or the constant desire to check up on that Facebook tab.

Jayesh recently went to a CISCO press conference (conducted over telepresence, no less!) and came back with some startling survey findings on the Indian Gen Y: Only 1 in 5 people spend more time with friends in person. Over 70 per cent compulsively check their smartphones for updates, while 42 per cent said they “would feel anxious, like part of me was missing” if they couldn't check their smartphones constantly. Looks like the human body has got its 207th bone, and it's a smartphone!

So what's with this strange predilection to be connected all the time? I have a theory. It is believed our sentience comes from two sources – the Conscious and the Subconscious. The conscious makes us aware of things that we've allowed ourselves to feel, while the subconscious is made up of our innermost feelings – what ordinarily one would call intuition. When a feeling passes to the conscious, is when we truly realise it. In today's era, I believe technology has given rise to a third layer in our psyche; what I'd like to call the web-conscious. Let me elaborate... Think of a truly momentous or a joyous occasion that recently happened in your life. Only until you put it up as a status message (and garnered a few likes) did you fully relish it. It's not just the big events. Every little minute thought and emotion these days needs to be broadcast before it is validated online and then registered in our conscious. It just goes to show how important our online selves have become to us. The second reason for wanting to be so connected is the principle of random payouts. This is the principle that makes chance based gambling so addictive. The reward comes

only once in awhile. It's the same with updates; every now and then there's one that'll crack you up or one that you truly “like”.

In the coming year I'm looking forward to better online communities, better forms of interaction and our online persona being used to affect some good. (And I don't mean Facebook groups that take up causes). My rationale is simple – if we are spending so much time online we might as well use it to enhance our lives even while interacting. As far as communities go, I see a lot of quality information exchange and interaction happening over at Quora (the startup is what Yahoo! answers could've been had it not been overrun by neanderthals). Now even Google+ has added communities and some of the popular ones (mostly around Android) seem to be worth a look. Recently Qyuki a social network centered around creativity was launched specifically for India. All encouraging stuff. But what about on a personal level?



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Can this obsession to broadcast banalities be put to good use? How about goal-setting via status message? A quick dipstick survey revealed that people are already doing this. They think of a status message that'll attract a lot of likes (kudos, if you will) and work towards that goal. Say you want to post something like “Cracked GMAT with a score of 720” you'd better get cracking and work towards it. Devices in the near future will come hot wired to post to Facebook. Imagine a weighing scale that does just that. Every kilogram drop will motivate you further.

This is just the beginning. In the coming year we'll see many newer forms of interaction online. So here's to a less fruity and more fruitful online life. 